Faithful in Babylon

Jeremiah 29 · Daniel 1, 3, 6, 7 · Jeremiah 31 · Ezekiel 36–37

The big idea: In exile God's people were to seek the welfare of Babylon and stay faithful, as Daniel and his friends did. In the ashes God promised a new covenant, a new heart, his Spirit, and a King whose kingdom will never end. Jesus brought the new covenant in his blood.

Before you meet: Read

Jeremiah 29:4–14 · Daniel 3:13–28 · Jeremiah 31:31–34 · Lamentations 3:19–24

Open (5 minutes)

How do you stay faithful in a place that does not share your faith?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"But seek the _____ of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf." *(Jeremiah 29:7)*

"But if _____, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods." *(Daniel 3:18)*

"I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their _____." *(Jeremiah 31:33)*

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his _____ never come to an end; they are new every morning." *(Lamentations 3:22–23)*

Discuss

1. God told the exiles to build, plant, and seek the welfare of Babylon. What would it look like for you to seek the good of your city? *Jeremiah 29:4–7*

2. Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego said, But if not. How does the cross show that God is good even when he says no? *Daniel 3:16–18*

3. The new covenant promises forgiveness, a new heart, and the Spirit. Which of these do you most need to believe today? *Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 36:26–27*

Memory verse

"The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

Lamentations 3:22–23

Pray

Bring God any sorrow or sense of exile you carry. Thank him that his mercies are new every morning. Thank Jesus for the new covenant in his blood, and ask the Spirit to write God's law on your heart.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 34

Faithful in Babylon

Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Jeremiah 29:4–14 and 31:31–34 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Ezra 1 and 3, and Nehemiah 8).

Main points to land

1. In exile God's people were to seek the good of Babylon and stay faithful, as Daniel and his friends did. God himself was their sanctuary (Jeremiah 29:7; Ezekiel 11:16).
2. In the ashes God promised a new covenant, a new heart, his Spirit, and a Son of Man whose kingdom will never end (Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 36:26–27; Daniel 7:13–14).
3. Jesus bore the Father's wrath as our substitute on the cross, the deepest exile, and established the new covenant in his blood to bring us home (Matthew 27:46; Luke 22:20).

Core doctrine to teach

The Sovereignty of God CORE DOCTRINE 17 OF 26

God rules over all things, including nations, kings, and history. Babylon burned the temple because God sent it as his judgment, and Babylon fell when God said so. Nothing happens outside his plan. Yet God never does evil, and people are still responsible for what they choose. His plan is good. *Daniel 4:34–35; Jeremiah 25:9; Isaiah 46:9–10; Ephesians 1:11; Psalm 115:3*

Answer key (Observe)

1. welfare
2. not
3. hearts
4. mercies

Questions people will ask

What about Jeremiah 29:11, I know the plans I have for you?

It is a real promise, but read it in context. God spoke it to exiles who were told to settle in Babylon for seventy years, and most of them died there (Jeremiah 29:4–10). His plans for welfare and a future were bigger than one lifetime and are fully kept in Christ. It is not a guarantee that every plan of ours will work out.

Closing prayer

Father, your mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning. Thank you that you did not abandon your people in exile, and that you gave them promises in the ashes. Thank you for Jesus, who bore your wrath for us on the cross and made the new covenant in his blood. Write your law on our hearts, fill us with your Spirit, and help us seek the good of our cities until you bring us home. Amen.